

Write Effective Emails

Getting people to do what you want



by Peter K. Johnson

Web Explorations

When this information could be helpful.

Ever send an email and have it be ignored?

Follow these five steps and you'll be amazed at the response you get to your emails.

Step 1. - Use Subject Line Alerts

You are probably sending an email in order to get somebody to do something for you.

Put the action you want the person to take in the Subject line.

That way, as they receive the email they will be alerted to what you are asking them to do.

Make it personal and informative so it is not mistaken for SPAM.

Example:

Subject: Question on my grade for Project: Calculator

Step 2. - Remind using First Line Alerts

After you address the person by name tell them specifically what you want them to do.

This may seem redundant after you just typed it in the signature line, but it isn't. By repeating your request you are adding emphasis to your request. Marketing people have known for years how effective it is to repeat the same message over and over and over and, well you get the point.

If you can keep your request to one line that makes it even more powerful.

Example:

Professor Johnson,

Would you review my grade for Project:Calculator?

Step 3. - Supply all the Details

Once you've told the person what you want them to do, then supply all the details. It is better to give them every bit of information they need so they don't have the excuse of not being able to complete your request.

Be succinct (a cool word for "keep it short and sweet")

Limit the details to 2-3 short sentences.

Break them up into paragraphs with blank lines in between for readability.

Example:

In the grade book you show that I have a zero for Project: Calculator. Yet, the dropbox shows that I submitted it early, two days before the due date.

I've attached a screen shot showing the date and time stamp on my dropbox submission.

Step 4. - Close with a Call to Action

Close your email telling the person what you want them to do.

As the person reads your email they will decide to do one of three things:

1. Should I delete this email?
2. Should I file this email?
3. What should I respond?

You want the reader to do step #3 with your email: What should I respond?

Our brains normally remember the last thing we hear or read. So, use this trick to remind the person what you want them to do as they decide what to do with your email.

Example:

Please review my work and post a grade in the gradebook. Let me know if I need to do anything else in order to receive credit for this project.

Thank you.

Step 5. - Use a Power Signature

Sign your email with a power signature block. This gives the email credibility.

- Your name and title
- Your company or organization you are affiliated with
- Your email (in case someone prints out your email)
- Your phone number
- Your website (Facebook, LinkedIn, or eFolio)

Example:

Mary North, Student

South Central College

Mary.North@gmail.com

123 - 456-7890

<http://MaryNorth.com>

Tip #1 - Say Please and Thank You

Don't forget the magic words.

Always include a “please” and “thank you” with your request.

Tip #2 - Spelling Matters

Spelling, capitalization, and grammar matter.

Business people often only know you by your email. If you write a sloppy email with improper spelling, capitalization, and grammar they are going to think you are sloppy. They will be very cautious on doing business with you, or even responding to your emails. A sloppy email is like going to a very fancy party wearing ragged jeans and sandals and uncombed hair. It may be okay with you, but the folks at the party will be very uncomfortable talking with you and most likely you'll miss out on some interesting possibilities.

If you want to write successful and effective emails make sure you use proper English and pay attention to spelling, capitalization, and grammar.

PaperRater is a free tool that will check your grammar, spelling, and capitalization.

Set up a bookmark to this site so you can get to whenever you are working on professional communications.

Tip #3 - Have one thought/action per email

Effective emails only ask the person to do one thing.

Having more than one thought/action confuses the reader.

Having a single task allows the reader to stay focused and complete what you are asking. It allows the person to tackle the problem and then delete the email from their inbox, knowing that the task is finished.

It much better to send many, short emails, each with its own subject or task, then it is to send several things you want the person to do all mixed together.

Closing

Would you hire this person?



This is an actual email along with the photo that the writer uses as her ID photo on Google+. The writer refers to Renee who is the HR Director for this company. Spelling, punctuation, and attitude are as the writer sent it.

Hey I'm hoping this can get to Rena she called me this morning and wanted to set up an interview, I wanted to just make sure that I would have the opportunity to work with children since that is the kind of job I am looking for.

Thanks,

[person's name]

Summary:

Follow these five steps and you'll be amazed at the response you get to your emails.

1. Use subject line alerts
2. Remind using first line alerts
3. Supply all the details
4. Close with a call to action
5. Use a power signature.

Tips

1. Use the magic words: Please and Thank you.
2. Spelling, grammar, and capitalization matter.
3. Have one thought/action per email.

Credits

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